

CONTACT Department of Economics
Georgia State University
Atlanta, GA
Phone: (470) 652-2702
Website: [rakadatta.github.io](https://github.com/rakadatta)
Email: dattarakaecon@gmail.com

FIELDS **Primary Field:** Health Economics
Secondary Fields: Labor Economics, Experimental Economics, Econometrics

EDUCATION **Georgia State University**, Atlanta, GA 2022–2027 (expected)
Ph.D. in Economics
Dissertation: “Essays on Health Economics”
Committee: Lauren Hoehn-Velasco (Chair), James Marton, Elaine Liu, Laura M. Argys
University of Bonn, Germany 2019–2022
M.Sc. in Economics
Jawaharlal Nehru University, India 2016–2018
M.A. in Economics
Jadavpur University, India 2013–2016
B.Sc. in Economics (Honors)

PUBLICATIONS **Neonatal Mortality Risk Among Births in Freestanding Birth Centers, 2015–2024**
with Lauren Hoehn-Velasco & Diana R. Jolles
Journal of Midwifery & Women’s Health, 2026. doi.org/10.1111/jmwh.70177
Neonatal Mortality Risk in Planned Home Birth, 2015–2024
with Lauren Hoehn-Velasco & Diana R. Jolles
Forthcoming, Journal of Midwifery & Women’s Health

WORKING PAPERS *Dissertation Chapters*
1. “Alcohol Access Shocks and Mortality” (Job Market Paper)
A substantial literature links the density of alcohol retail outlets to adverse health and social outcomes, but this evidence is often correlational and confined to a single city or region. In this paper, I provide causal evidence on whether physical alcohol retail access affects mortality. I develop a mortality-risk extension of the rational addiction model with access costs, and test its predictions against reduced-form estimates. I identify the effect from county-level, over-time variation in County Business Patterns liquor store establishment counts, matched to restricted-access NCHS Multiple Cause of Death mortality microdata, across U.S. counties from 1989 to 2016, and estimate two-way fixed effects and event-study specifications. Each additional liquor store per 100,000 residents raises alcohol-primary mortality by 0.048 deaths per 100,000 annually, a 0.65% increase relative to the pre-treatment mean. The effect is three times larger for off-premise retailers (e.g., liquor stores) than for on-premise establishments (e.g., bars), and concentrated among older adults, consistent with a chronic rather than acute consumption channel. Valued at a central value of a statistical life of \$11.6 million, the estimated effect implies approximately \$556,000 in annual mortality damages per additional store per 100,000 residents.
2. “Professional Recommendations and Provider Behavior”
with Lauren Hoehn-Velasco, Elizabeth Humphreys, & Nancy A. Niemczyk
Provider responses to updated clinical guidelines play a central role in shaping health outcomes. In this study, we examine how physicians respond to new randomized controlled trial (RCT) evidence. We analyze physician behavioral changes following the publication of the ARRIVE trial in obstetrics, which found that elective induction at 39 weeks can reduce cesarean delivery in low-risk, first-time pregnancies. Using nationally representative U.S. birth certificate data from 2016 to 2021, we document a rapid and sustained increase in 39-week inductions for low-risk first births by approximately 9%. Following the trial’s release, inductions not only increase among first births but also among subsequent births, suggesting “off-label” application of the trial findings. Despite this significant shift in clinical practice, we find no corresponding decline in cesarean sections for first births. These findings highlight a significant discrepancy between trial-based findings and real-world application: while providers respond to high-quality clinical evidence, the anticipated downstream benefits may not surface. Our results highlight the importance of evaluating how evidence translates into practice and challenge the assumption that RCT findings necessarily imply population-level improvements.

3. “The Long-term Impact of In-Utero Alcohol Taxes on Adult Prenatal Drinking”

with Godwin Aipoh

Prior research documents the effects of alcohol tax on alcohol consumption, drinking behavior and birth outcomes. Long-term intergenerational effects of prenatal exposure to alcohol tax policies remain relatively unexplored. We investigate whether in-utero exposure to alcohol tax (mid-1940s to early 1990s) shapes adult prenatal drinking behaviors and transmits health effects across generations. We use restricted birth certificate data and employ a time and location fixed effects model to analyze the effect of historical alcohol tax rates during gestation and later-life adult pre-pregnancy/prenatal alcohol use. We also use event studies to further isolate and evaluate the long-run effects of alcohol tax-induced behavioral changes on adult health outcomes and the intergenerational spillovers on infant health. Our findings suggest that higher in-utero alcohol taxes significantly reduce adult prenatal drinking, potentially offering insights into the durability of early-life policy interventions.

WORK IN PROGRESS	“Advertising and Consumer Behavior in the Post-Dobbs Era” with Sukriti Beniwal & Nikita Dhingra “State-Paid Leave and Healthcare Utilization for Infants” with Godwin Aipoh “Heat Waves, Fertility, and Labor Market Outcomes in the U.S.” “Does Time Bridge Gaps? Long-Term Dynamics of the Child Penalty in Women’s Earnings”		
RESEARCH EXPERIENCE	Graduate Research Assistant , Department of Economics, Georgia State University 2022–present Research Assistant , IZA – Institute of Labor Economics, Bonn, Germany 2020–2022 <i>Gender, Growth and Labor Markets in Low Income Countries Program</i>		
TEACHING EXPERIENCE	Primary Instructor ECON 2106: Principles of Microeconomics Spring 2025, Fall 2025 Teaching Assistant ECON 8030: Mathematical Methods for Economists (PhD) Fall 2023, 2024, 2025 ECON 4230: Experimental Economics Spring 2025, 2026 ECON 3910: Microeconomics 2024, 2025 Teaching Certification GSU Center for Excellence in Teaching, Learning and Online Education (CETLOE) Spring 2024		
GRANTS & AWARDS	External APPAM Excellence, Equity and Inclusion Student Fellowship (2026) American Institute for Research Fellowship Fund (2026) Georgia State University Professional Development Fund Award, AYS Career Services E.D. (Jack) Dunn Fellowship and Research Fund (×2) Bernard B. and Eugenia A. Ramsey Chair Funding (×2) W.J. Utery Chair of the American Workplace Funding Andrew Young Fellowship (3 years) University of Bonn & JNU University of Bonn: STIBET-I Fellowship JNU: Indira Gandhi Fellowship		
PRESENTATIONS	2026: Population Association of America Annual Meeting; Eastern Economic Association Annual Meeting; ASHEcon Annual Conference; American Institute for Research Conference; Southern Economic Association; APPAM Fall Research Conference 2025: Southern Economic Association; APPAM Fall Research Conference; ASHEcon Annual Meeting		
SKILLS	Software: Stata, R, Python, L ^A T _E X, oTree/zTree, MS Office Key Datasets: NVSS, HCUP, Nielsen Retail Scanner & Ad Intel, County Business Patterns, NHTSA, BRFSS, PSID		
REFERENCES	Lauren Hoehn-Velasco (Chair) Assistant Professor Department of Economics Georgia State University lvelasco@gsu.edu	James Marton Chair and Professor Department of Economics Georgia State University marton@gsu.edu	Laura M. Argys Executive Director, Rocky Mountain Research Data Center School of Public Health Univ. of Colorado, Denver laura.argys@ucdenver.edu